# The Amazing Bone

## By William Steig

**NARRATOR:** It was a brilliant day, and instead of going straight home from school, Pearl dawdled. She watched the grownups in town at their grownup work, things she might someday be doing. She saw the street cleaners sweeping the streets and she looked in at the bakery on Parsnip Lane and saw the bakers taking hot loaves of pumpernickel out of the oven and powdering crullers with sugar dust. On Cobble Road she stopped at Maltby's barn and stood gawking as the old gafers pitched their ringing horseshoes and spat tobacco juice. Later she sat on the ground in the forest between school and home, and spring was so bright and beautiful, the warm air touched her so tenderly, she could almost feel herself changing into a flower. Her light dress felt like petals.

**PEARL:** I love everything.

**BONE:** So do I.

**PEARL:** *(straightening up and looking around)* Where are you?

**BONE:** Look down. I'm the bone in the violets near the tree by the rock on your right.

**PEARL:** *(following the directions and searching near the tree. She finds the BONE and speaks in awe)* You talk?

**BONE:** In any language. Habla espanol? Rezumiesh popolsk? Sprechen sie Deutsch? And I can imitate any sound there is: *(sounds of a trumpet calling soldiers to arms. Then wind blowing, then like pattering rain. Then snoring, then sneezing)*

## INTRODUCTION

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**PEARL:** *(couldn't believe what she was hearing.)* You're a bone. How come you can sneeze?

**BONE:** I don't know. I didn't make the world.

**PEARL:** May I take you home with me, wonderful bone?

**BONE:** You certainly may. I've been alone a long time. A year ago, come August, I fell out of a witch's basket. I could have yelled after her as she walked on, but I didn't want to be her bone any longer. She ate snails cooked in garlic at every meal and was always complaining about her rheumatism and asking nosy questions. I'd be happier with someone young and lively like you.

**NARRATOR:** Pearl picked the bone up and gently put it in her purse. She left the purse open, so they could continue their talk, and started home, forgetting her schoolbooks on the grass. She was eager to show this bone to her parents, and she could guess what would happen when she did. She would tell about the talking bone, her mother would say

**MOTHER:** You're only imagining it

**NARRATOR:** Her father would agree, and then the bone would flabbergast them both by talking. The spring green sparkled in the spring light. Tree toads were trilling.

**PEARL:** It's the kind of wonderful day, when wonderful things happen – like my finding you.

**BONE:** Like ***my*** finding ***you***! *(And it began to whistle a walking tune)*

**NARRATOR:** That made the going very pleasant. But not for long. Who should rush out from in back of a boulder and spoil everything but three highway robbers with pistols and daggers. Pearl couldn't tell what breed of animal they were, because they wore cloaks and Halloween masks, but they were fierce and spoke in chilling voices.

**ROBBER 1:** Hand over the purse!

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**NARRATOR:** Pearl would have gladly surrendered the purse, just to be rid of them, but not with the bone in it.

**PEARL:** You can't have my purse.

**ROBBER 2:** What's in it? *(pointing his gun at Pearl's head.)*

**BONE:** *(growling)* I'm in it! *(And it began to hiss like a snake and roar like a lion.)*

**NARRATOR:** The robbers didn't wait around to hear the rest, in case there was any more. They fled so fast you couldn't tell which way they'd gone. It made Pearl laugh. The bone, too. They continued on their way, joking about what had just happened and chatting about this and that. But it wasn't long before a fox stepped forth from behind a tree and barred their path. He wore a sprig of lilac in his lapel, he carried a cane, and he was grinning so the whole world could see his sharp white teeth.

**FOX:** Hold everything! *(Pearl froze.)* You're exactly what I've been longing for -- young, plump, and tender. You will be my main course at dinner tonight. *(he seized Pearl in a tight embrace.)*

**BONE:** *(screaming)* Unhand her, you villain, or I'll bite your ears off!

**FOX:** *(surprised)* Who is that speaking?

**BONE:** A ravenous crocodile who dotes on fresh fox chops, that's who!

**NARRATOR:** The wily fox was not as easily duped as the robbers. He saw no dangerous crocodile. He peered into Pearl's purse, where the sounds seemed to be coming from, and pulled out the bone.

**FOX:** *(holding up the bone)* As I live and flourish! A talking bone. I've always wanted to own something of this sort. *(And he put the bone in his pocket)*

**BONE:** *(roaring and ranting)*

**NARRATOR:** Pushing Pearl along, the fox set out for his hideaway. Pearl's sobs were so pitiful the fox couldn't help feeling a little sorry for her, but he was determined she would be his dinner.

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**PEARL:** *(sobbing, whimpering and pitiful)* Please, Mr. Fox, may I have my bone back, at least until I have to die?"

**FOX:** Oh, all right. *(disgusted with himself for being so soft-hearted, he handed her the bone, which she put back in her purse.)*

**BONE:** You must let this beautiful young creature go on living. Have you no shame, sir!

**FOX:** *(laughing)* Why should I be ashamed? I can't help being the way I am. I didn't make the world.

**BONE:** You coward! You worm, you odoriferous wretch!

**FOX:** *(snarling)* Shut up, or I'll eat you. It would be amusing to gnaw on a bone that talks . . . and screams with pain.

**NARRATOR:** The bone kept quiet the rest of the way, and so did Pearl. When they arrived at the fox's hideaway, he shoved Pearl, with her bone, into an empty room and locked the door. Pearl sat on the floor and stared at the walls.

**BONE:** *(whispering)* I know how you feel.

**PEARL:** *(also whispering)* I'm only just beginning to live. I don't want it to end.

**BONE:** I know.

**PEARL:** Isn't there something we can do?

**BONE:** I wish I could think of something, but I can't. I feel miserable.

**PEARL:** *(hearing some sounds from the kitchen)* What's ***that***?

**BONE:** *(whispering)* He's sharpening a knife.

**PEARL:** *(sobbing quietly)* Oh, my goodness! And what's ***that***?

**BONE:** Sounds like wood being put into a stove.

**PEARL:** I hope it won't all take too long

**NARRATOR:** She could smell vinegar and oil. The fox was preparing a salad to go with his meal.

**PEARL:** *(Pearl hugged the bone to her breast.)* Bone, say something to comfort me.

**BONE:** You are very dear to me.

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**PEARL:** Oh, how dear you are to me!

**NARRATOR:** She could hear a key in the lock and was unable to get another word out of her throat or turn her eyes toward the door.

**BONE:** *(whispered)* Be brave.

**NARRATOR:** Pearl could only tremble. She was dragged into the kitchen, where she could see flames in the open stove.

**FOX:** *(sighing)* I regret having to do this to you. It's nothing personal.

**BONE:** "***Yibbam***!"

**FOX:** *(standing stock-still)* What was that?

**BONE:** Yibbam sibibble! Jibrakken sibibble digray!

**NARRATOR:** And something quite unexpected took place. The fox grew several inches shorter.

**BONE:** Alabam chinook beboppit gebozzle!

**NARRATOR:** Miraculously the fox was the size of rabbit. No one could believe what was happening, not Pearl, not the fox, not even the bone, whose words were making it happen.

**BONE:** Adoonis ishgoolak keebokkin yibapp!

**NARRATOR:** The fox, clothes and all, was not the size of a mouse.

**BONE:** Scrabboonit!

**NARRATOR:** And the mouse – that is, the minuscule fox – scurried away and into a hole.

**PEARL:** *(exclaiming)* I didn't know you could do magic!

**BONE:** Neither did I.

**PEARL:** Well, what made you say those words?

**BONE:** I wish I knew. They just came to me, I ***had*** to say them. I must have picked them up somehow, hanging around with that witch.

**PEARL:** You're an amazing bone, and this is a day I won't ever forget!

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**NARRATOR:** It was dark when they reached Pearl's house. The moment the door swung open she was in her mother's arms, and right after that in her father's.

**MOTHER:** Where on earth have you been?

**FATHER:** We were frazzled with worry.

**PEARL:** *(holding up the bone)* This bone can talk!

**NARRATOR:** And just as she had expected, her mother said,

**MOTHER:** A talking bone? Why, Pearl, it's only your imagination.

**NARRATOR:** And her father said something similar. And also as Pearl had expected, the bone astonished them both by remarking,

**BONE:** You have an exceptional daughter.

**NARRATOR:** Before her parents had a chance to get over their shock, Pearl began telling the story of her day's adventure, and the bone helped out. It was all too much for Pearl's parents. Until they got used to it. The bone stayed on and became part of the family. It was given an honored place in a silver tray on the mantelpiece. Pearl always took it to bed when she retired, and the two chatterboxes whispered together until late in the night. Sometimes the bone put Pearl to sleep by singing, *(sing a lullaby here)* or by imitating soft harp music. Anyone who happened to be alone in the house always had the bone to converse with. And they all had music whenever they wanted it, and sometimes even when they didn't.

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